Chapter Twenty-Five

The Sack of Constantinople

Between 1195 and 1204, Crusaders serve themselves, and Constantinople falls

THE FINAL CRUSADE of the twelfth century was a sordid series of landgrabs that barely bothered to wave the cross.

In 1195, the emperor Isaac Angelus lost his throne when his older brother, Alexius, mounted a revolt; Isaac Angelus had grown unpopular after a series of fruitless military ventures, and Alexius was able to claim popular support. He imprisoned his brother and then blinded him, after which he allowed the disabled ex-emperor to live in relative comfort. Isaac's thirteen-year-old son, also named Alexius, was taken prisoner as well; but by 1201 his uncle had decided to give him the freedom to move about the city. According to Nicetas Choniates, the boy, now nineteen, paid a Pisan merchant ship to smuggle him through the Hellespont and out into the Mediterranean.[1]

The ship docked at Sicily. From there, young Alexius made his way to the royal court of Germany. The Holy Roman Emperor Henry VI had died unexpectedly of malaria in 1197, at the age of thirty-two. The German noblemen had elected his younger brother Philip as his successor (although Philip had not yet received the crown of the empire from the pope's hand); and Philip had married young Alexius's sister, Isaac Angelus's second daughter, Irene.

Alexius's arrival at his sister's palace in Germany soon galvanized the Fourth Crusade.